

Appalachian Backroads, Windy 9 & Golf

Eleven days in a loop from Athens, Ohio, the hub of the Windy 9: the Hocking Hills and Triple Nickle, West Virginia's Midland Trail and New River Gorge, the coal-country roads of south-west Virginia including the Back of the Dragon, and home through the Virginia highlands and Seneca Rocks, with golf at The Greenbrier and The Homestead. About 1,715 miles.

11 days: 9 riding, 2 golf · **Start and finish:** Athens, OH (fly into Columbus, one hour away) · **Best:** late September to mid-October

Best time to go

- **Best:** late September to mid-October. Cool, dry riding weather and fall colour, peaking in the Virginia and West Virginia mountains in mid to late October.
- **Good:** late May to June. Mild temperatures and rhododendron and mountain laurel in bloom.
- **Hardest:** July and August. Hot and humid, with afternoon thunderstorms most days.
- **Note:** leaf-peeping weekends are busy around The Greenbrier and The Homestead; book golf and rooms early.

Arrive Columbus to Athens, Ohio

Fly into Columbus and transfer to Athens, about an hour south-east, where all nine Windy 9 routes start and end. Collect the bike in Athens.

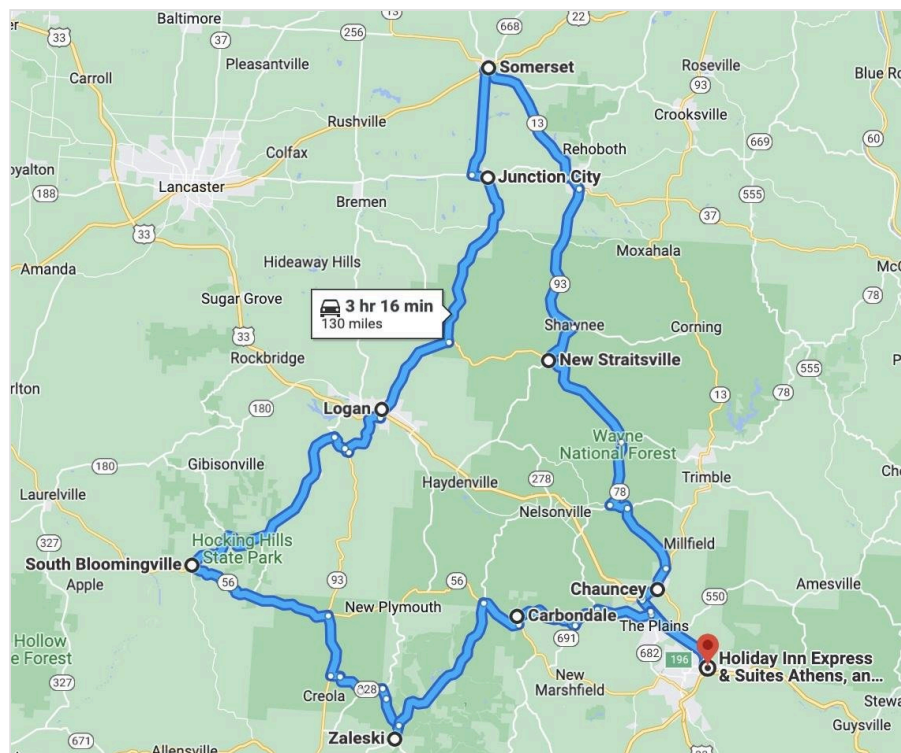
Overnight: Athens

Day 1 Athens loop

About 130 miles

Windy 9: Hocking Hills Nipper, Black Diamond Run & Zaleski Zipper

A loop out of Athens into the Hocking Hills: Logan, Hocking Hills State Park, Zaleski State Forest and New Straitsville in Wayne National Forest, back to Athens.



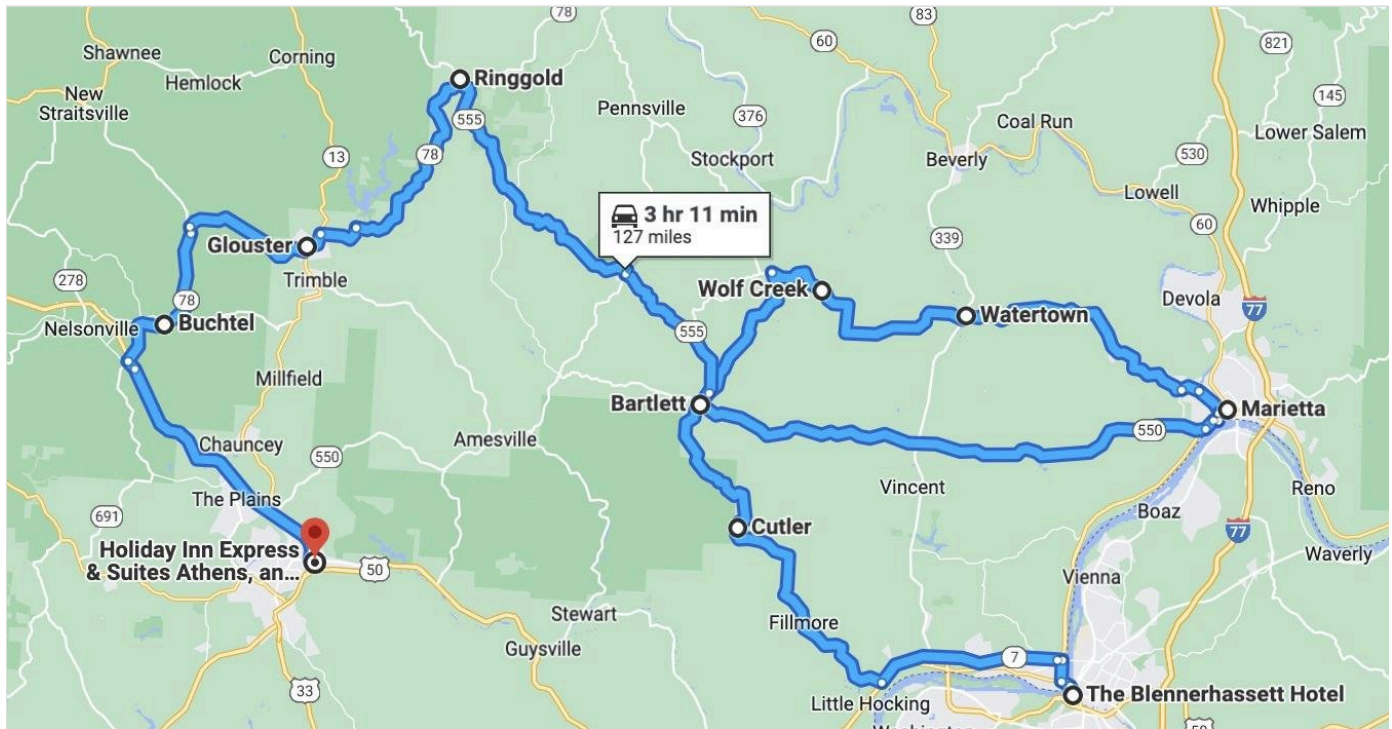
Overnight: Athens

Day 2 Athens, OH to Parkersburg, WV

About 130 miles

Windy 9: Triple Nickle, Pioneer Pass & Rim of the World

East on the Triple Nickle (OH-555) through the hill country to Marietta on the Ohio River, then across into West Virginia at Parkersburg.



Shown from Parkersburg to Athens; ride it in reverse.

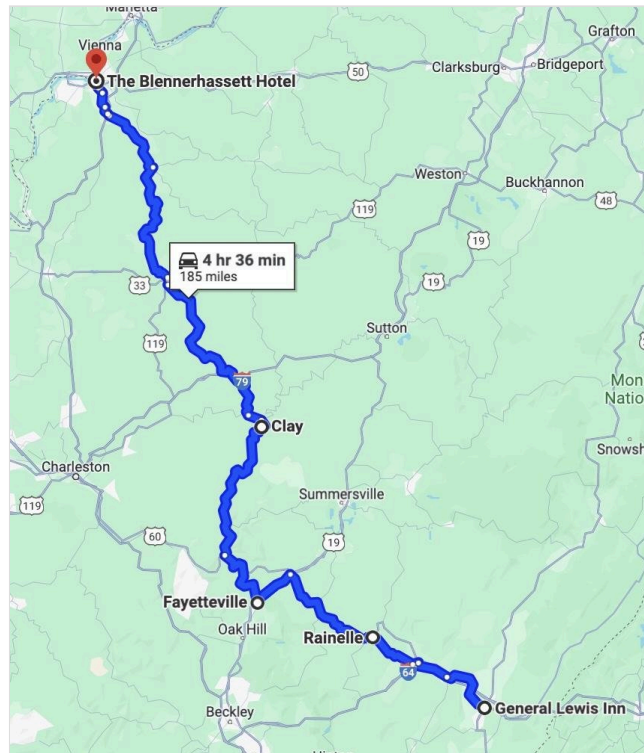
Overnight: Parkersburg

Day 3 Parkersburg to White Sulphur Springs, WV

About 195 miles

The Midland Trail and the New River Gorge Bridge

South through Clay to Fayetteville and the New River Gorge Bridge, then east on the Midland Trail (US-60) through Rainelle and Lewisburg to The Greenbrier.



Shown from Lewisburg to Parkersburg; ride it in reverse.

Overnight: The Greenbrier, White Sulphur Springs

Day 4 Golf at The Greenbrier

A round on the Old White TPC, the 1914 course that hosted the PGA Tour's Greenbrier event. Two more courses on the property if you want a second round.

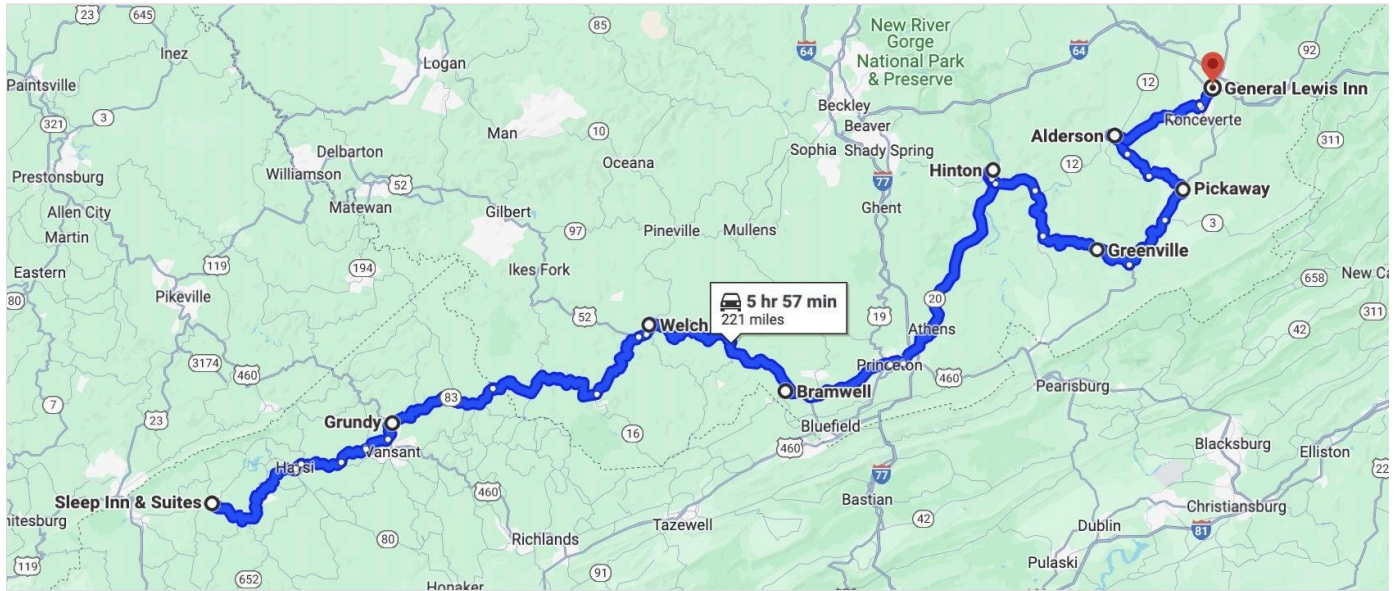
Overnight: The Greenbrier

Day 5 White Sulphur Springs to Wise, VA

About 230 miles

Coal Heritage Trail & the Bootlegger

Through Alderson and Hinton, the Coal Heritage Trail past Bramwell's millionaire houses and Welch, then Grundy and into the far south-west corner of Virginia.



Shown from Clintwood to Lewisburg; ride it in reverse.

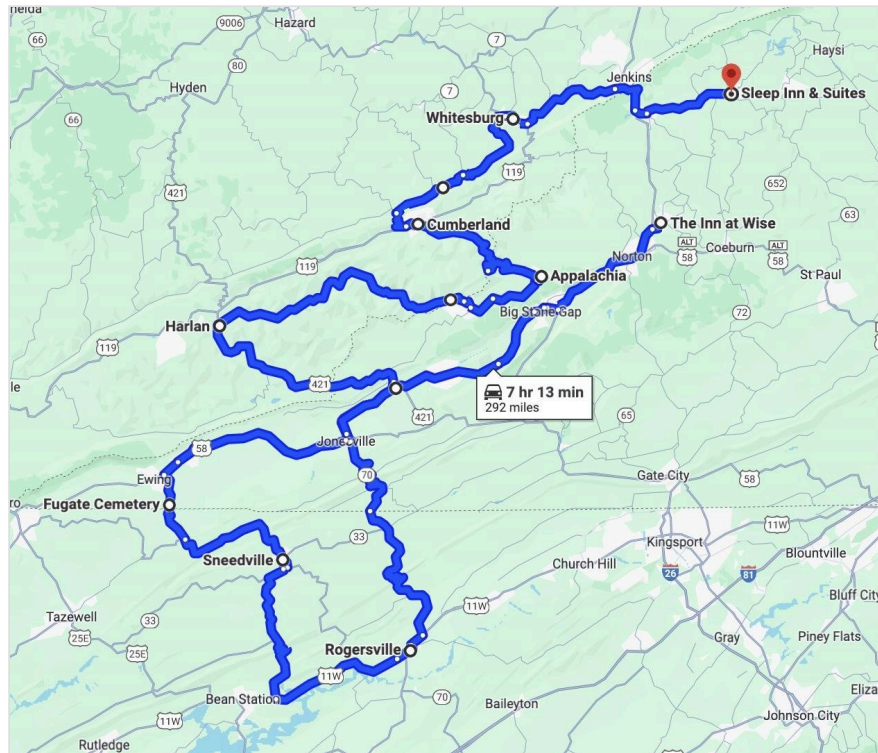
Overnight: Wise

Day 6 Wise loop

About 250 miles

The Woodbooger, Skull Cracker, Black Snake & Eagle's Nest

The coal-country loop through Kentucky and Tennessee: Harlan, Sneedville and Rogersville, then back over Big Stone Gap. Visit Axe Handle Distillery in Pennington Gap.



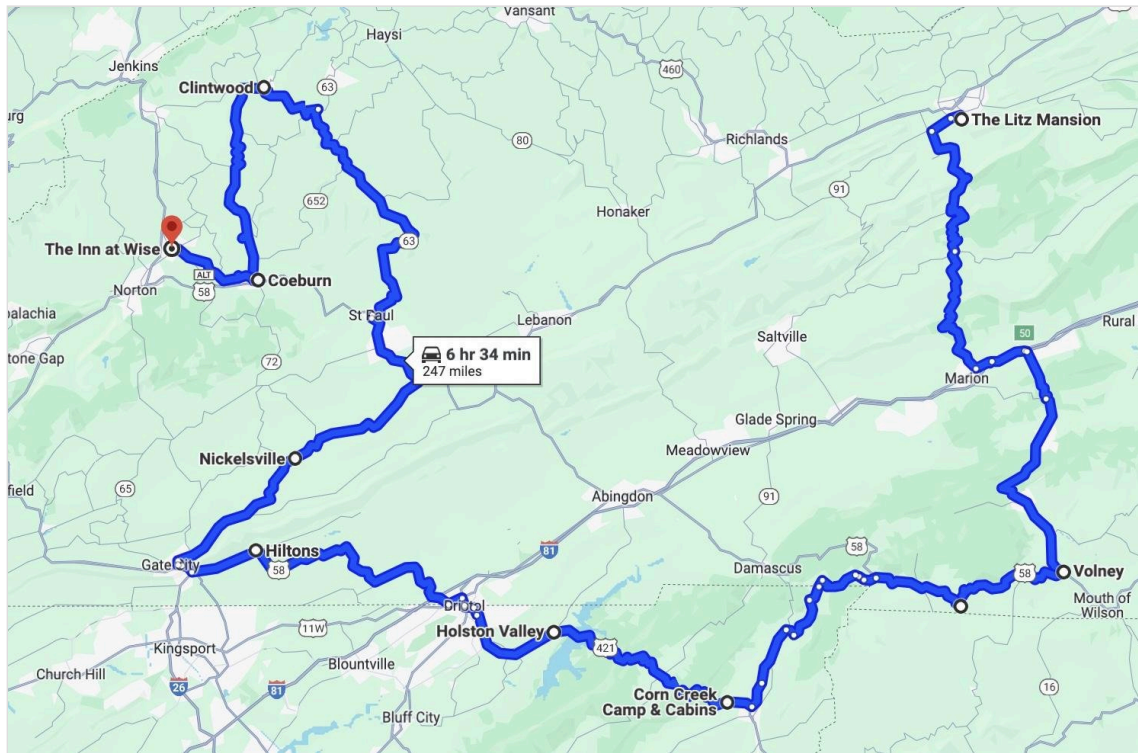
Overnight: Wise

Day 7 Wise to Tazewell, VA

About 245 miles

Back of the Dragon, Shady Valley, RoadRunner & Heartbreaker

South to Gate City and Holston Valley, east to Damascus and over the Heartbreaker to Volney, then north from Marion over the Back of the Dragon (VA-16), 438 curves in 32 miles, into Tazewell.



Shown from Tazewell to Wise; ride it in reverse.

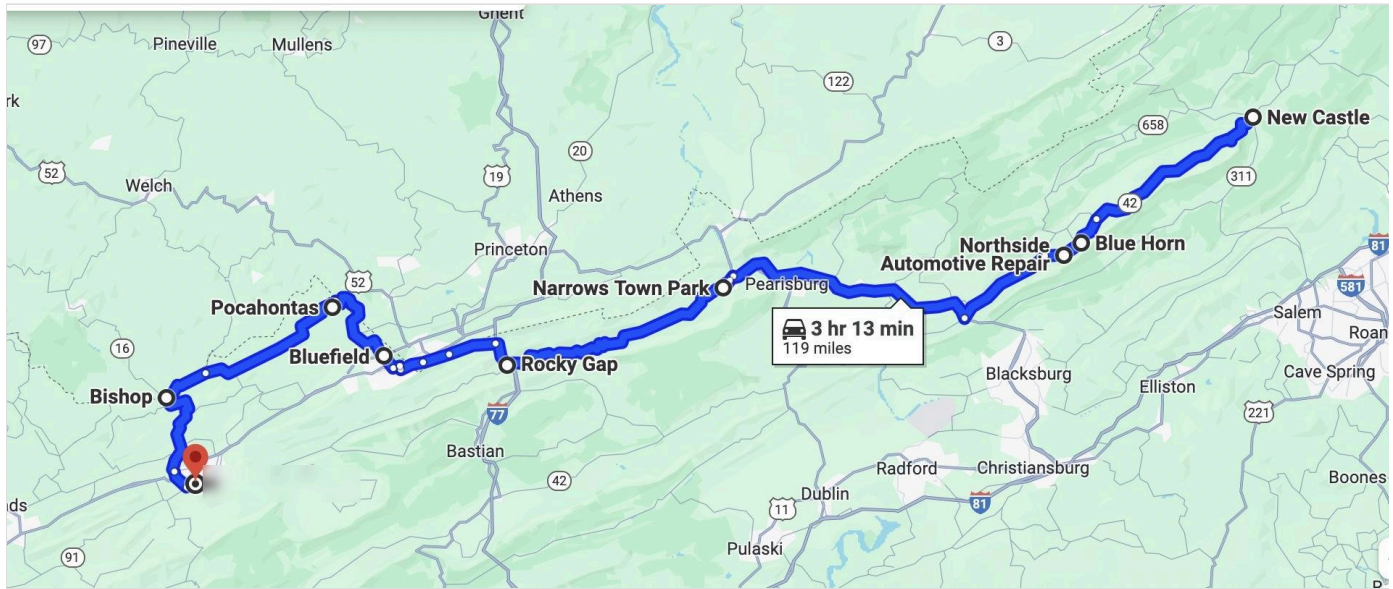
Overnight: Tazewell

Day 8 Tazewell to Hot Springs, VA

About 180 miles

The Scorpion

East through Bluefield and Narrows to New Castle, then north through Covington into the Bath County hills to Hot Springs.



Shown from New Castle to Tazewell; ride it in reverse.

Overnight: The Omni Homestead, Hot Springs

Day 9 Golf at The Homestead

A round on the Cascades Course at The Omni Homestead, one of the best mountain courses in the country, and an evening soak in the Warm Springs pools.

Overnight: The Omni Homestead

Day 10 Hot Springs, VA to Elkins, WV

About 165 miles

The Virginia highlands and Seneca Rocks

North through Warm Springs into Highland County, the “Switzerland of Virginia”, to Monterey, then over the Allegheny ridges into West Virginia past Seneca Rocks and through the Monongahela National Forest to Elkins.

Overnight: Elkins

Day 11 Elkins, WV to Athens, OH

About 190 miles

West through Buckhannon and the West Virginia hills to Parkersburg, across the Ohio River and back to Athens to return the bike. Transfer to Columbus to fly home, or stay one more night in Athens.

Golf

- The Greenbrier, White Sulphur Springs, WV: Old White TPC, plus the Greenbrier and Meadows courses
 - The Omni Homestead, Hot Springs, VA: the Cascades Course
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Bike rental in Athens

- There are no rental shops in Athens itself. Riders on the Windy 9 commonly rent through **Twisted Road** (twistedroad.com), a peer-to-peer network where local owners rent out their bikes, including BMW GS models. Search for pickup in or near Athens, and confirm the owner is fine with 1,700 miles and four states.
 - Athens Sport Cycles is the local dealer for service and tyres along the way.
 - Back-up: rent in Columbus and ride the hour to Athens on the first morning.
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Riding notes

- Back of the Dragon, the Woodbooger and the Coal Country rides are tight, technical roads with gravel in the corners; ride them in daylight.
 - Fuel is sparse in the coal country of south-west Virginia; fill up whenever you can.
 - Allow time on Day 8 and Day 10: the Virginia highland roads are slow and twisty.
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Draft route. Distances are approximate. Maps are from the original plan; some days are shown in the opposite direction.